Shabda-bodha: understanding from words and sentences. A person understands what is said when they hear or read a grammatically correct sentence (*vakya*) expressing a genuinely possible state of affairs. Sometimes the speaker's intention (*tatparya*) is taken into account.

Further reading: Ganeri 1999

Shabda-pramana: language as an instrument of knowledge. It may inform or move to action. *Shabda* (lit. the sound of a word) may be the testimony of reliable persons or *Vedic* scriptural language (***shruti***), or the *Agamas* recognised as authorities by the non-*Vedic* or *Tantric* religious cults. Language is accepted as an instrument of knowledge in its own right by all philosophical schools excepting materialists, Buddhists and ***Vaisheshikas***. The ***Nyaya*** school says that a person is a reliable authority when they are not in error, have no intention to deceive, are neither drunk nor confused and when their sense faculties are working normally.

The mainstream orthodox Ritualists (***Purva-Mimamsa)*** and ***Vedantins*** hold that the relation between a Sanskrit word in the ***Vedas*** and the object that it means is innate, natural and eternal. According to both schools, the *Vedic* scriptures have no author, human or divine. They are simply given. *Vedic* language is only a source of knowledge about whatever lies beyond the range of sensory perception: thus it cannot be contradicted by those ***pramanas*** whose operation is restricted to the sphere of sense-based experience and nor can it contradict them.

The permanent relation obtains between general terms for kinds of things and particular entities. Thus, 'cow' in isolation stands for the generic property or form (***akriti***) shared by all individual cows. So the word–object connection is neither created when a calf is born nor